



Beijing 2008

ARCHERY

Bull's Eye for BEIJING

India's archery team to the Olympic Games is made up of a maverick from Jharkhand and three women who between them could make history

■ By Elora Sen

Dark clouds are hovering overhead and the rain is coming down in torrents over the Sports Authority of India (SAI) Eastern Centre in Kolkata's Salt Lake neighbourhood. These are hardly conditions for men and women to be hanging around, getting soaked and shooting arrows in the open.

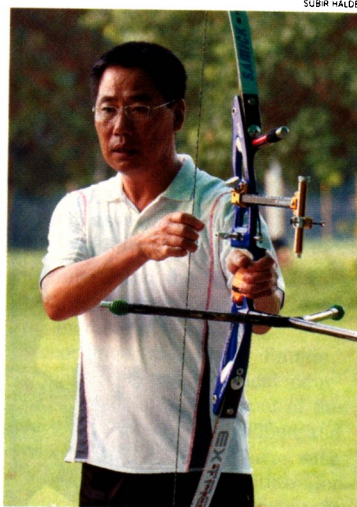
Yet, regardless of the frowning weather, the Indian Olympic archery team continues to fire streamlined missiles at their targets, watched by a stern-faced Korean, who, it is clear, is their coach, confidant and slave driver. With time counting down to the Olympic gamers in Beijing at what seems like rapid speed, the weather has failed to halt the team's practice session. Unlike the sky, the archers' mission is very clear. It has to be bull's eye in Beijing.

Archery Association of India (AAI) general secretary Paresh Mukherjee is also clear in his mind. He thinks of India's Olympic results as "a national shame". He sighs, "Such a big population and no champions." Then he throws down the gauntlet to the archers around him. "This time," he says, "the archery team wants to change that. They will go to the Olympics, to compete, not to participate." Confident words from a man who has experienced all the slings and arrows that have come the way of Indian archery.

Four years ago, India's largest ever

team left for the Athens Olympics at a time when archery's profile was the highest it's ever been in India.

In the 2003 World Archery Championships in New York, the Indian men's recurve team had finished fourth (out of a field of 37 nations) and the women team sixth (out of 32 nations). India was only one of the three teams to have both men and women qualifying for the 2004 Olympics. In the wake of such a heady run-up, results were



"If Champia withstands the Games atmosphere, he can win a medal."

LEE WANG WOO, TEAM COACH



SUBIR HALDER

mixed. Satyadev Prasad reached the quarter-finals, one round short of having a shot at a medal, while Reena Kumari finished among the top 16. There were no medals from the team, but these are still India's best-ever Olympic performances.

For Beijing, the Indian archery squad is made up of rookies with only one Olympic veteran. Unlike the 3-3 split in Athens, this time there are three women and one man heading east for their biggest test. The only experienced archer is Dola Banerjee, 28, who had an excellent run in 2007, winning the World Cup Grand Finals in Dubai. Banerjee had also won the fourth stage of the World Cup circuit in Dover in England to qualify for the Dubai finals as one of only four elite archers.

In Beijing, Banerjee will shoot alongside Laishram Bombayla Devi, 23, and 17-year-old Vardeneni Pranitha in the team event. The two rookies came through tough qualifying rounds, which saw Olympian Reena